United States.[3] By 2005–06, Washington, now under the leadership of George W. Bush, offered to support India's full emergence as a global power, in part (but only that) in order to create a balance of power in Asia as China' power grew. As New Delhi moved towards strategic partnership with the United States, it realised it needed to forego ties with Iran that endangered India's larger, overriding interest in a stable and deep partnership with the United States. Indian critics of their country's new partnership with the United States decried India's sacrifice of its strategic autonomy and tailing after the United States. But the architects of India's new US relationship deemed Washington more important than Tehran to India's rise. India disengaged from its short first "strategic partnership" with Iran while India's partnership with the United States flourished. The Chabahar and North–South Corridor projects were suspended and would not be resumed until after the 2015 nuclear deal with Iran. New Delhi's quest for stable partnership with the United States led India to scupper its first attempt at strategic partnership with the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Several observations emerge from this thumbnail history of China, India, Iran, and US relations. First, both Beijing and New Delhi prioritised ties with Washington over ties with Iran. Both Beijing and New Delhi viewed Iran as an important potential partner but also recognised that the stakes of their relations with the United States far outweighed their relations with Tehran, and both drew back from Tehran when they determined that was necessary to protect their links to Washington.

Second, the lifting of sanctions on Iran under the JCPOA opened the way to intensified Chinese–Indian rivalry for position in Iran. During the long period in which the United States used its vast influence to pressure Iran over its nuclear programmes, elements of Chinese–Indian rivalry toward Iran were not discernible, at least not to the eyes of this analyst. Once sanctions on Iran were lifted, Beijing and